Virtually, the first question that colleagues at NUS, many of them experienced authors themselves, have asked me when I told them about the book was, ‘Who is your target reader?’ A straightforward answer eluded me. There are economists, analysts and commentators who know the Reserve Bank but are keen on understanding how the Reserve Bank’s mind operates. Then there are several times that number of educated and intelligent people who do not know much about the Reserve Bank but are eager to understand how its policies affect them. Both those groups are my target readers. To paraphrase Einstein, I have tried to make the book as simple as possible, but no simpler.

It is customary for a preface to end with a vote of thanks. If I do so now, it is not so much to pay homage to a tradition but to acknowledge many people who encouraged and supported me in this project. First and foremost, my thanks to the NUS authorities for generously allowing me the time and space to write the book in the intellectually stimulating university environment. A special thanks to Dean Bernard Yeung at the business school who attached so much value to the scholarly pursuit of a book that he kindly agreed to free me of other obligations so that I could focus on writing.

I needed specific information on certain topics from the Reserve Bank. Deputy governors Harun Khan and R. Gandhi, under advice from Governor Raghuram Rajan, supplied me notes on such topics, always on the mutual understanding that the notes they gave me could be put out in the public domain. My sincere thanks go to them and their support staff who serviced me with the quiet efficiency that is the hallmark of the Reserve Bank. Susobhan Sinha, my former executive assistant at RBI, went way beyond the call of duty to act as an intermediary between me and the notes suppliers at the RBI, with his characteristic efficiency and energy that I have so taken for granted. Alpana Killawala, chief of the Reserve Bank’s communications department, kindly provided me a CD of the press clippings which were of invaluable help in constructing the basic narrative on each topic.